

Instead, he was left, like Eden, with a house with two mortgages on it and some debts. Much of his money went into escrow at first, which means it was being held by a third party as a midway point. Penty had a lawyer help him figure out some of his English father's dental bills. People he expected to be understanding were not. His father's dentist of thirty years immediately demanded her money in full without apology, even though she'd been a family friend. (He'd tried to work out a payment plan with her office.) That's when Penty realized no one was going to play nice just because he was now an orphan.

PREPARING (FINANCIALLY) FOR DEATH

It's not fun to think about, but we're all going to lose our parents or guardians someday, if we haven't already. For when that happens, here are some things to know:

- ° You might not have to pay their hospital bills. This one blew me away. Not paying them back gives your dead parents (or loved one) a bad credit score, but as Eden said, "Who cares? They're dead." Be careful though: commonwealth.com reported that many states have "filial responsibility" statutes that sometimes hold adult children responsible for a deceased parent's medical debt. Make sure you know what the laws are in your state.
- ° You don't have to pay back their credit card debt unless you cosigned on the card. Eden's dad had a credit card balance of \$30,000. She told the company her dad had died, and she was unemployed. All she could afford to pay was \$5,000. The company said "okay." "I was so mad that I didn't ask for less!" she said. "They know that most of the time, they just don't get anything."
- ° If you're inheriting a positive amount after debts have been settled and the funeral has been paid for, think carefully for at least six months about where that money should go. Penty says that's how long you need to grieve before you can make a level-headed decision. In his piece for *Billfold*, he wrote that he invested the money in buying a home in